

LUXURY EXPEDITION CRUISES

Wonders of Japan Cruise: Cherry Blossom Season 2023

14 days from $45,495 per person *was $47,495*

Limited to 199 guests

OFFER

Book early and save $2,000 per person on all stateroom categories and suites.

Experience fascinating Japan during springtime with a chance to witness the country's iconic cherry blossoms alongside a professional photographer. Spanning five islands, this all-encompassing cruise explores Japan's culturally rich coastline with a pre-cruise stay in Osaka and included shore excursions throughout, including a visit to Hiroshima's Peace Memorial Park, the Adachi Museum of Art and its gardens, and Kanazawa's historic district.

Included With This Luxury Expedition Cruise

- An Exclusively Chartered, All-Inclusive Voyage Led by A&K's Expedition Team and Local Guides
- Pre- and/or Post-Cruise Stays at Stylish, Ideally Located Hotels and A&K-Led Excursions
- Airport Meet and Greet and Transfers
- Private Balcony with Every Onboard Accommodation and Butler Service with Every Suite
- Maximum Personnel-to-Guest Ratio of 1 to 1.3 and ship occupancy limited to 80 percent
- Culinary Program Featuring French-Inspired Cuisine, Including House Drinks, Afternoon Tea and Pastries
- 24-Hour Room Service and Breakfast in Bed on board
- Choice of Curated, All-Inclusive Shore Excursions
- Enrichment program, lectures and presentations
- Traveller's Valet® Laundry Service on board
- All Gratuities, Port Charges and Taxes
- Complimentary Wi-Fi on Board and in Hotels
- Onboard Service from an English-Speaking Staff, Including an Accredited Physician
- 24/7 A&K On-Call Support

A&K Advantages

Witness private performances by the world-renowned Kodo taiko drummers, Kabuki warriors and geishas
Immerse yourself in mesmerizing Japanese gardens, perhaps visiting the gardens at the Adachi Museum of Art
Visit Gyeongju, South Korea, ancient dynastic capital and UNESCO World Heritage Site
Reflect on Japan's turbulent history and witness its miraculous resurgence in Hiroshima
Enjoy fascinating onboard lectures and presentations led by our enrichment specialists on Japanese history, culture and gardens

Featured Experts



MARK EDWARD HARRIS

Photo Enrichment Coach

With award-winning photography in publications that include LIFE, Mark is also the author of *The Way of the Japanese Bath*, *North Korea* and most recently *The People of the Forest*, which focuses on orangutans.



SIMON RICKARD

Japanese Gardens Lecturer

Former head gardener at Australia's iconic Heronswood and the Garden of St Erth, Simon runs his own gardening design consultancy. He has led many expeditions to Japan and is excited to return during cherry blossom season.

Itinerary



MAR 29 ARRIVE OSAKA, JAPAN

Meet your A&K representative and transfer to your ideally located hotel. Spend the remainder of the day at leisure.

The Ritz-Carlton Osaka

MAR 30 OSAKA | CULTURAL WONDERS

Begin your adventure with a full-day excursion to Kyoto, where you visit the Golden Pavilion (Kinkakuji Temple), attend a talk about Zen Buddhism at Tenryuji Temple and explore Nijo Castle. Alternatively, you can enjoy a historic journey to Nara, the first Japanese capital, and a visit to Horyu-ji, the country's oldest temple. For an incredible overview, take a scenic drive to Uji, possibly enjoying the sight of cherry trees blossoming along Uji River. Gather with fellow guests this evening for a welcome reception and dinner, complete with a Kabuki performance.

The Ritz-Carlton Osaka | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

MAR 31 OSAKA | THE ADVENTURE BEGINS

After breakfast at your hotel, enjoy the morning at leisure or join a panoramic tour of Osaka that includes a visit to the Dotonbori district and the imposing Osaka Castle. Enjoy lunch followed by a stroll through the wandering paths of Taiko-en Garden, admiring its ponds and stone bridges. This afternoon, transfer to Kobe, where you board your luxurious expedition cruiser and home for the next 11 nights.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 1 TAKAMATSU | EXPLORE YOUR WAY

Wake up in charming Takamatsu, the gateway to Shikoku Island. Opt for a boat ride to Shodoshima, the heart of Japan's olive-growing industry, for a full-day tour. You may otherwise remain on Shikoku Island. Here, your day starts with a visit to picture-perfect Ritsurin Park, one of Japan's finest gardens. Next, explore the Kinashi area of Takamatsu, among the country's main bonsai production centers, where you learn about traditional methods of growing and caring for these meticulously cultivated little trees. A few others may travel to Naoshima Island by ferry for a full-day excursion, celebrating its architecture and art museums. Visit the hillside Chichu Art Museum and stop at Benesse House, a complex featuring unique work by both Japanese and international artists.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 2 HIROSHIMA & MIYAJIMA | MEMORIALS & SHRINES

Vibrant and full of historical significance, Hiroshima is home to magnificent memorials and shrines. Start the day with a visit to the beautiful Peace Park and Museum, with its somber cenotaph containing names of atomic bomb victims. Then, take a speedboat ride to Miyajima Island, site of the iconic Torii Gate and the Daisho-in Buddhist temple. Or enjoy a full-day excursion through Hiroshima, visiting the Hiroshima Castle and namesake Peace Park and Museum, where you attend a private talk with an atomic bomb survivor. If you prefer a day in nature, head out to the tranquil island of Miyajima. Ascend Mount Misen by cable car for a hike, admiring the Shinto shrine and Torii Gate from above.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 3 UWAJIMA | SEASIDE SPLENDOR

Spend the day in Uwajima, situated on the west coast of Shikoku and home to Japan's main producers of pearls, for a glimpse of small-town living. While there, learn the process of cultivating and sorting pearls during a visit to a pearl farm. Continue to the samurai-era gardens of Tensha-en, with their spectacular mountain backdrop. Alternatively, explore Nanraku-en Garden, the largest on Shikoku, and enjoy a scenic hike in picturesque Yakushidani Canyon. Another option is a historic stroll to Yoshida along a cherry tree-lined lane, followed by an old town visit that includes a historic Kabuki theater. Return to the ship for a relaxing evening on board.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 4 KARATSU | ANCIENT TRADING POST

This afternoon, your luxury expedition vessel arrives at the port of Karatsu. Once an early trading post between Japan and mainland Asia, Karatsu still maintains its medieval heritage. Visit Karatsu Castle, known as the "flying crane castle." Tour the Hikiyama Exhibition Hall, which houses the floats and artifacts used in the annual Karatsu Kunchi autumn festival. Alternatively, head to the city of Imari to visit its celebrated porcelain pottery kilns and the Mifuneyama Rakuen garden.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 5 GYEONGJU, SOUTH KOREA | KOREAN CAPITAL

Disembark in Ulsan and spend a full day exploring Gyeongju, South Korea, the ancient UNESCO-designated capital of the Silla Dynasty. Gyeongju's heritage dates back to the first millennium. Witness its excavated temples, tombs and pagodas; view the exceptional collection of jewelry, weapons and pottery at the National Museum; and sit down to a lunch of Korean delicacies and a traditional dance performance. Alternatively, pay a shorter visit to Gyeongju as well as a visit to the Hyundai factory.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 6 MATSUE, JAPAN | VERDANT GARDENS

Return to Japan and disembark at Sakaiminato to visit Matsue, the "town of water." Explore the countryside, pausing to wander through the picturesque Yuushien Garden. Enjoy lunch at a local restaurant before visiting historic Matsue Castle, one of Japan's few remaining medieval castles, built in original wooden form. Art

lovers can visit the Adachi Museum of Art, which melds the founders' passions for art and garden design. After a traditional lunch at a ryokan (inn), visit Yakumo-mura village to learn about the art of Japanese paper making.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 7 KANAZAWA | IMMERSION INTO THE ARTS

Spend the day in the thriving art center of Kanazawa, known for its Kutani-style pottery and gold-leaf workmanship, followed by a visit to Edo-period Kenrokuen Garden, among the best in Japan. Wander Omicho Market with its fresh flowers and fish, and then stroll in the Higashi Chaya-gai district with its well-preserved historic geisha houses. Other options include a hike in Kakusenkei Gorge followed by a soothing onsen (hot spring) experience, a visit to Kanazawa's Oumi market with a cooking demonstration, or a visit to the countryside to the Shogawa River valley. This evening, enjoy an exclusive geisha performance.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 8 SADO-GA-SHIMA | KODO TAIKO DRUMMERS

Arrive at pastoral Sado Island, with its rice paddies, bamboo groves and surf-pounded seacoasts. Political exiles and deposed emperors were once "banished" to live on this beautiful isle. Enjoy an exclusive private performance by the Kodo taiko drummers, and then visit the Hakusanmaru Exhibition Hall and Ogi Folk Museum, followed by a farmer's talk at the rice paddies.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 9 AT SEA | HOKKAIDO ISLAND CRUISING

Enjoy a relaxing day on board while cruising toward Hokkaido. Share stories and photographs with newfound friends and take advantage of the ship facilities, including the panoramic fitness room and sauna.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 10 OTARU | HISTORIC CANALS

Arrive in Otaru, your gateway to Hokkaido, Japan's largest and northernmost island. Visit the city known for its canals, sake distilleries, architecture and views of Mount Tengu. Opt for a historical and cultural tour of the city, once a prosperous fishing village; visit a sake distillery, where you may sample the rice wine; and learn about Japanese whiskey during a tasting and tour at Nikka Whisky Yoichi Distillery Alternately, choose to spend the day in Sapporo, discovering its parks and landmarks, and visiting its colorful market and Hokkaido museum.

'Le Soleal' | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 11 DEPART SAPPORO

Disembark luxury 'Le Soleal' in Otaru. Transfer to the airport in Sapporo and board your homebound flight or continue on the Tokyo post-tour extension.

Meals: Breakfast

Note: Itinerary is for guidance purposes only and may be adjusted due to unforeseen circumstances including weather, medical emergencies and other conditions beyond A&K's control at the sole discretion of the Captain.

While the itinerary is scheduled over estimated cherry blossom dates, this natural phenomenon is subject to climate and weather, and cannot be guaranteed. Excursions may be altered to offer optimum opportunities to view the cherry blossoms if available.

Extensions



Kyoto Pre-Tour Extension

Discover timeless Kyoto, visiting its temples and gardens, exploring its buzzy districts and witnessing its traditions.

4 days from $4,595 per person
Single Supplement from $2,295 per person

MAR 26

Arrive in Osaka and transfer to Kyoto, cultural and historic capital of Japan. Check into your tranquil hotel and enjoy the rest of the day at leisure.

Hyatt Regency Kyoto

MAR 27

Travel through the busy lanes of the Higashiyama district to Kiyomizu Temple. Visit its main hall, a remarkable 17th-century wooden structure set on a steep cliff and offering panoramic views of Kyoto. Take a guided tour of a machiya, a traditional wooden town house, and try on a kimono. After lunch, return to your hotel for time at leisure.

Hyatt Regency Kyoto | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch

MAR 28

Set out on an enlightening tour of Kyoto. Visit the iconic rock garden at Ryoan-ji Temple, considered a supreme example of an abstract Zen garden, and Arashiyama, where you take in its famed bamboo grove and stroll its Togetsukyo Bridge over the picturesque Katsura River.

Hyatt Regency Kyoto | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch

MAR 29

Transfer to Osaka and begin your main Luxury Expedition Cruise program.

Meals: Breakfast, Lunch



Tokyo Post-Tour Extension

Explore Tokyo’s markets and museums, experience hands-on art making, and take a day trip to Hakone.

4 days from $6,395 per person
Single Supplement from $2,495 per person
✈ Sapporo/Tokyo

One-way internal air included

APR 11

Fly to Tokyo. Enjoy lunch at a local restaurant and check in to your hotel.

Conrad Tokyo | Meals: Lunch

APR 12

Visit one of Tokyo’s exciting markets and Imperial Palace Plaza. Alternately, travel to Hakone, enjoy a boat tour on Lake Ashi and visit Hakone's Open Air Museum, followed by a puzzle box-making experience.

Conrad Tokyo | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch

APR 13

Visit the Asakusa district and Shunkaen Bonsai Museum, or visit the Meiji Shrine and Nezu Museum with an Edo-period dyeing experience, or visit a sumo training quarters and the Edo-Tokyo Museum. This evening, join fellow guests for a farewell dinner.

Conrad Tokyo | Meals: Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner

APR 14

Transfer to the airport and board your homebound flight.

Meals: Breakfast

Dates & Prices

Prices are in USD, per person, based on double occupancy.

Dates	Prices	Single Supplement	Availability
Mar 29 - Apr 11, 2023			
Category 1 - Classic Stateroom	$20,995 (was $22,995)	$17,245	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 2 - Deluxe Stateroom	$23,495 (was $25,495)	$19,125	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 3 - Premier Stateroom	$24,495 (was $26,495)	$19,875	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 4 - Superior Stateroom	$30,495 (was $32,495)	$24,375	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 5 - Prestige Suite	$35,995 (was $37,995)	$34,195	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 6 - Premier Two-Room Suite	$45,495 (was $47,495)	$43,225	Call for Availability
Category 7 - Prestige Two-Room Suite	$47,995 (was $49,995)	$45,595	Waitlist - Call A&K
Category 8 - Owner's Suite	$54,995 (was $56,995)	$52,245	Waitlist - Call A&K

Optional pre-tour and post-tour extensions available on this departure.

Journey Details

Proof of full vaccination for COVID-19 is required for this journey, including a booster shot if vaccination was received more than four months prior to departure (two months for the Johnson & Johnson vaccine).

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While the itinerary is scheduled over estimated cherry blossom dates, this natural phenomenon is subject to climate and weather, and cannot be guaranteed. Excursions may be altered to offer optimum opportunities to view the cherry blossoms if available.

This journey contains some active elements, including Zodiac boat excursions, walks over uneven terrain and optional, challenging hikes.

Minimum age is 7 years.

Categories 5–8 include room upgrade at the hotel and butler service aboard the ship.

First group event: excursion on Mar 30.

Last group event: disembarkation by 9:00 a.m. on Apr 11.

Special Offer Terms & Conditions

Offer subject to availability and may be withdrawn at any time.

Prices are per person based on double occupancy. Internal and international air not included. See complete terms and conditions here.